THE MAN WHO SET THE WORLD ON FIRE

As the Mughal Empire grew dramatically during this period through Akbar's extensive military campaigns, the Padshah instituted precise administrative measures to bring these territories into the Mughal fold. Hindustan had long been an agricultural economy and, through the centuries, appropriation of agricultural surplus was the primary means of revenue generation for the rulers. Under the Tughlaqs, and then under the Afghan Lodis especially, control over revenues of territory increasingly became hereditary, leading to a dangerous leavening of power bases, as had happened with Sulaiman Karrani Afghan and then his son, Daud Khan. After his return from the Bihar campaign, Akbar brought in a number of changes in the administration, some of which he had been working on previously, to centralize power and control the influence of his ever-widening nobility. It was at this stage that Akbar systematized the administration of the mansab, or number-rank, for every imperial officer, or 'man of the sword'. Instead of being given a salary with its attendant obligations in an arbitrary manner, officers now had a very specific place in a hierarchy of numerical ranks which determined the salary of the official and the number of horses that he was expected to maintain in case military duties arose. Thus, a mansabdar of 500 rank, for example, would have to maintain a force of 500 horses and he would be assigned a salary which would allow him to raise that force.* The salary could be given in cash but was usually in the form of a land revenue assignment, the jagir. The jagirs were assigned strictly for revenue collection and these were now regularly transferred. Neither the mansab rank nor the jagir land were hereditary, thereby encouraging personal loyalty to the Padshah, and not to any regional grouping or dispensation. While there were other aspects of the administration—the land-revenue system and the branding of animals—that were legacies of earlier dynasties, the mansab system was truly unique and, according to historian M. Athar Ali, 'an unrivalled device for organizing the ruling class'. 'These men were specialists,' according to historian Stephen P. Blake, 'devoting their lives to the arts of war.' The low ranking mansabdars, of 20-400, were vital to the Mughal army and filled 'minor